

Practicing safer sex

STDs can be transmitted via foreplay and during all types of sex. They may be spread through contact with the genitals or through exchanging bodily fluids (including blood, semen, and discharge from the vagina and anus). There are various ways to reduce the risk of catching or transmitting an STD. Here are just a few:



Using barrier contraceptives

Using a condom is probably the easiest way to protect against STDs. But remember that some STDs can still be transmitted by other parts of the body and bodily fluids coming into contact.



Having regular STD tests

Some STDs don't have any visible symptoms, so if a person is sexually active, they should get tested regularly just in case.



Avoiding certain sexual practices

Sex is the most common way an STD can be passed on, so sticking to low-risk activities, such as masturbation or foreplay, will reduce the risk of catching one.



Choosing sexual partners carefully

When a person refuses to have sex with a potential partner who is having sex with other people, or until they have had an STD test, they are practicing safer sex.



Avoiding alcohol and drugs

Drinking alcohol and taking drugs affects a person's ability to make judgments. A person may plan to stick to masturbation or foreplay, or use condoms, but end up engaging in unsafe sex if they are under the influence of alcohol or drugs.



Not having sex

Being abstinent is choosing not to have sex or engage in any type of sexual activity. When practiced properly, abstinence is the only method that is 100 percent effective against STDs. If a teen decides they don't want to have sex, others should respect their decision.